

Apple iBooks 3.0

Apple's iBooks 3.0 Update has finally gone live in the App Store, with features similar to the Amazon Kindle



Microsoft Office 2013

Microsoft confirmed that the company is planing to release a native iOS and Android version of Office 2013 next year

HOW WE TESTED

We called for Mini ITX boards that sported a processor onboard, as we were looking at boards that will make for a good home-theatre PC or a second PC at your home. The only components we used on these boards for all these boards were the Corsair HX 620W power supply, the BenQ EW2430 monitor, an Intel SSD with the Windows 7 64-bit OS (except for certain boards which required Windows 7 32-bit OS) and Kingston HyperX 4 GB RAM (except for some boards which only took laptop RAM memory in which case we used Kingston 4 GB RAM). We did not put in any discrete GPU as not all boards came with a PCIe x16 slot.

We put a lot of stress on the features offered by the boards, as they are entry level boards ideal for the most basic tasks. Boards with USB 3.0 and on-board Wi-Fi got more points. Similarly boards, which had an on-board processor with internal graphics helped give better scores in the graphics related benchmarks. We ran the boards through our standard set of benchmark tests, at lower settings of course. Since these boards are not meant to be performance power-houses, we kept the weightage lower on the performance parameters which weren't very pertinent such as rendering or gaming. We gave the HD movie viewing experience a higher score as that is one task that we expect an HTPC to do best. We noted the CPU utilization while both our test HD clips were running, with the help of a utility called CPUMon. Also higher stress was laid on the USB read speeds, as we realised that since we are looking at an HTPC board, we would have to get most of the content from an external media if you didn't already have a shared network. Overall, we gave a 60 percent weightage to features and specs and 40 percent to performance.

on both the boards are placed very close to the DIMM slots. Although both boards lack USB 3.0 ports, they feature HDMI, DVI and D-sub ports.

Intel Boards

In the Intel stable we had three boards namely D2700DC, D2500HN and D2700MU all based on the Intel Atom Cedar Trail platform. All three boards look very similar in terms of board layout with a few additions and subtractions here and there. One major difference between these boards and the ones from AMD was the presence of SO-DIMM slots. Other component layout design is more or less similar. The D2700DC and D2700MU sport a PCIe mini card slot, to add in an mSATA component. The heatsink is passive and has many fins to enhance cooling. The D2500HN and the D2700MU sport the parallel

and serial ports that we saw on the Gigabyte AMD boards above, which means that these boards are clearly targeted for office use. The D2700DC on the other hand has the HDMI port along with the optical S/PDIF out ideal for home use.

VIA Board

ASRock PV530-ITX was the only board we got which was based on a VIA chipset. It houses the VIA PV530 processor along with VIA VX900 chipset. The board layout is quite decent with the processor having a passive cooler with a fan and the chipset having just the passive heatsink. Just like the Gigabyte boards,

this one too comes with legacy ports, there are more electrolytic capacitors than solid-state ones, a PCI slot and no USB 3.0 ports. The option to charge your USB devices while the system is in stand-by or off mode is a good plus.

Performance

With the Intel boards we noticed a peculiar thing. When we installed the 64-bit Windows 7 OS, it installed all drivers except the graphics driver. Only when we installed a 32-bit version did we see the Driver downloads section on the Intel website showing the GMA drivers. The native screen resolution of our monitor was supported with Windows 32-bit OS whereas the 64-bit OS only went upto 1280x1024. While the HD clips ran smooth, keeping the CPU utilisation under 15 percent, lower even than the AMD boards, the graphics on the Intel boards wasn't enough to pass the CineBench R11.5 Open GL test. Gaming is out of the question on these boards with their onboard graphics.

Speaking of gaming, even the AMD boards which sported DX11, did not return any great frame rates either for resolutions as low as 1024x768. So if you want to game on the AMD boards, you will have to make do with games that are old and they should be run on low resolutions. All the AMD boards ran both the HD clips quite



Foxconn AHD1S-V

smoothly but CPU utilisation was not as great as that seen on the Intel boards. Encoding songs from .MP3 to .AAC was fastest on the ASUS E35M1-I followed by the Foxconn AHD1S-V. The Intel boards were quite close. ASRock VIA board was the slowest when it came to encoding music. When it came to transcoding a video clip from .VOB to .DIVX we found the Intel D2700MU and D2700DC boards to coming out the fastest thanks to hyper-threaded cores, followed by the E350 boards. Here again the ASRock VIA board was the slowest.

Verdict

We awarded the Best Buy to Foxconn AHD1S-V board for its decent performance at very economical pricing of ₹3,300. If you are looking for the most basic board which will playback your HD content and help you with casual surfing and document work, go for the Foxconn AHD1S-V board as it offers the best bang for the buck.

The Editor's Pick was awarded to the ASUS E35M1-I Deluxe board. This board offers a boatload of features such as USB 3.0 ports, on-board WiFi which makes it an ideal candidate for an HTPC and perfect for wireless content streaming.

Chipset info				
Chipset	Hudson M1	Hudson D1	Intel NM10	VX900
Platform	Brazos	Value Lynx	PineTrail	VIA PV530
SATA	6 x 6Gbps	6 x 3Gbps	2 x 3Gbps	2 x 3Gbps
USB 2.0 ports	14	14	8	8
USB 3.0 ports	0	0	0	0
PCI	0	4	2	2
PCIe	4	4	0	0